

Handwriting Might Have Identified Famous Byzantine Artist

Crime-solving methods might have provided an answer to an ancient mystery — the identity of a leading Byzantine painter.

The artist Giotto who lived in Italy about 700 years ago is often considered the father of Western painting. But at the same time that Giotto lived, Manuel Panselinos was equally important to a different tradition: the art of Byzantium.

The art of Byzantium can be found in Eastern Orthodox churches across Greece, Serbia and other Orthodox countries. Byzantium is an ancient name for the modern city of Istanbul.

Who was Panselinos?

Nothing is known of Panselinos' life. Historians now believe Panselinos was a nickname. They now suspect his real name was likely Ioannis Astrapas. He was from the northern Greek city of Thessaloniki.

Work said to be made by Panselinos, from the late 1200s and early 1300s, is considered the finest produced in the Byzantine empire. That ancient empire covered parts of Europe and Asia. It lasted from the fall of the Roman Empire until the capture of the capital Constantinople by the Ottoman Turks in 1453.

Christina Sotirakoglou a handwriting expert, prints Byzantine paintings based on photographs, at her office, in Thessaloniki, northern Greece, Saturday, Nov. 30, 2024. (AP Photo/Giannis Papanikos)

Art historians had long suspected that “Panselinos” could have been a nickname, or a pseudonym, for a member of the Macedonian School of painting in Thessaloniki. The name means “full moon” in Greek.

Recent research by a Greek monk and a language expert have linked Panselinos with Macedonian School painter Astrapas.

Now handwriting expert Christina Sotirakoglou has found new evidence. She matched lettering on a document thought to be by Astrapas with writing on a church painting at Mount Athos in northern Greece. The Protaton church painting has been considered Panselinos' best work.

Father Cosmas Simonopetritis is a former administrator at Mount Athos; the religious community is where the Protaton church stands. He said Sotirakoglou's and his own research “clearly prove” Panselinos' real identity.

“Panselinos was a real person, and (the name) was just the nickname by which Ioannis Astrapas became known,” Simonopetritis told the Associated Press (AP).

Constantinos Vafiadis is a professor of Byzantine art who was not involved in the research. Vafiadis said he found strong points in the nickname theory and naming Astrapas as the true artist. However, he added that it appeared more than one painter had created the art at the Protaton church.

“I agree with attributing part of the paintings to Ioannis Astrapas,” Vafiadis said. “But again there remains much ground for future research into that person, because other Mount Athos monuments from the same period have not yet been sufficiently published.”

“Panselinos” and his fellow artists at the time are linked with a rebirth in Eastern Orthodox art. Their work brought back forms and skills inherited from ancient times. Facial expressions got a deeper humanity, and greater attention was paid to proportion and depth of field in composition.

Simonopetritis said Astrapas was an “extremely gifted painter” with deep knowledge. He added that Astrapas mixed “the ancient, classical world with Orthodox Byzantine spirituality.”

Christina Sotirakoglou a handwriting expert, observes Byzantine paintings based on photographs prints, at her office, in Thessaloniki, northern Greece, Saturday, Nov. 30, 2024. (AP Photo/Giannis Papanikos)

How they did it

The trail started with linking Astrapas to the person who wrote a book called the Marcian Codex GR 516 from the early 1300s. The book contains artwork and is handwritten in Greek. Among the painted pictures, or illustrations, is a full moon.

“For me ... that was the main proof,” Simonopetritis said.

With a name found for the person who produced the manuscript, the next step was to compare it to the writing on the painting in the Protaton church that has been traditionally linked with “Panselinos.”

“Mrs. Sotirakoglou, who is a handwriting expert, filled in that blank,” Simonopetritis said.

But women have for more than 1,000 years been banned from entering the Mount Athos religious community.

“I was forced to study the Protato paintings based on photographs,” Sotirakoglou told the AP. Sotirakoglou works as a court expert who examines handwriting in criminal cases.

The first clue came from the Greek letter “Phi,” the English “F,” in the Marcian codex manuscript.

“It’s a Phi that stands out, and is similar” in both the manuscript and the Protato painting, she said. “Matches also followed with other letters, T, with its proportions, which is bigger, covering the other letters and is topped with a curve, the proportions of the K.”

“But when the Phi was revealed, the code of the writing was broken and the job became much easier,” she added.

Father Cosmas said that during his duties on Mount Athos he attended services at the Protaton church every day.

“That’s where my desire was born...to explore the mystery around the name and the identity of Panselinos,” he said, adding that he thinks the artist has now gotten “his true identity.”

I’m John Russell.

Costas Kantouris and Nicholas Paphitis reported this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

nickname - n. ชื่อที่ใช้เรียกแทนชื่อจริงของบุคคล มักเป็นชื่อที่บ่งบอกลักษณะหรือเป็นชื่อที่คุ้นเคย

monk - n. สมาชิกชายของกลุ่มศาสนาบางศาสนาที่อาศัยอยู่ในชุมชนแยกจากสังคมส่วนใหญ่ และไม่ได้แต่งงานหรือมีทรัพย์สินมากนัก

handwriting - n. การเขียนด้วยมือ

attribute - v. พิจารณาหรือนับว่าเป็นผลงานที่ทำในลักษณะที่ระบุ (สันนิษฐานว่าเป็นผลงานของ)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What ancient mystery might crime-solving methods have helped to resolve?

- A) The identity of an ancient Roman emperor.
- B) The location of a lost Byzantine treasure.
- C) The true identity of a leading Byzantine painter.
- D) The reason for the fall of the Byzantine Empire.

2. According to the text, who is often considered the father of Western painting?

- A) Manuel Panselinos
- B) Ioannis Astrapas
- C) Giotto
- D) Father Cosmas Simonopetritis

3. Where can Byzantine art primarily be found?

- A) In museums across Western Europe.
- B) In Eastern Orthodox churches.
- C) In the modern city of Istanbul only.
- D) In ancient Roman temples.

4. What do historians now believe about the name "Panselinos"?

- A) It was the artist's birth name.
- B) It was a pseudonym for a group of artists.
- C) It was a nickname, with his real name likely being Ioannis Astrapas.
- D) It was a title given to the best Byzantine painter.

5. Where was Ioannis Astrapas, believed to be Panselinos, originally from?

- A) Mount Athos
- B) Constantinople
- C) Thessaloniki
- D) Rome

6. How long did the Byzantine Empire last?

- A) From the late 1200s to the early 1300s.
- B) Until 1453.
- C) For exactly 700 years.
- D) From the fall of the Roman Empire until the 12th century.

7. What is Christina Sotirakoglou's profession?

- A) An art historian.
- B) A language expert.
- C) A handwriting expert.
- D) A church administrator.

8. What does the name "Panselinos" mean in Greek?

- A) Great painter
- B) Full moon
- C) Bright star
- D) Macedonian artist

9. What two types of experts were involved in the recent research that linked Panselinos to Astrapas *before* Christina Sotirakoglou's new evidence?

- A) A language expert and an art historian.
- B) A Greek monk and a language expert.
- C) A handwriting expert and a church administrator.
- D) An archeologist and a historian.

10. Where was the church painting, considered Panselinos' best work, located?

- A) In Thessaloniki
- B) In Istanbul
- C) At Mount Athos
- D) In Serbia

11. Who is Father Cosmas Simonopetritis?

- A) A current administrator at Mount Athos.
- B) A professor of Byzantine art.
- C) A former administrator at Mount Athos.
- D) A language expert collaborating with Christina Sotirakoglou.

12. What was Constantinos Vafiadis's main reservation about attributing *all* the art at Protaton church solely to Astrapas?

- A) He believed the research methods were flawed.
- B) He thought Astrapas's work was not the finest produced in the empire.
- C) He suspected more than one painter had contributed to the art there.
- D) He disagreed with the nickname theory entirely.

13. What specific artistic elements were highlighted in the rebirth of Eastern Orthodox art associated with "Panselinos" and his contemporaries?

- A) The use of bold, abstract patterns and vibrant colors.
- B) A deeper humanity in facial expressions, and greater attention to proportion and depth of field.
- C) Themes focused primarily on historical events rather than religious figures.
- D) A shift towards Western European painting styles and techniques.

14. What was the initial step in the investigation to link Astrapas to Panselinos, as described in the "How they did it" section?

- A) Comparing handwriting on church paintings.
- B) Analyzing the symbolism of a full moon in Byzantine art.
- C) Linking Astrapas to the author of the Marcian Codex GR 516.

D) Interviewing historians from Thessaloniki.

15. After identifying the author of the Marcian Codex, what was the next logical step in the research regarding the Protaton church painting?

- A) To publish the findings immediately.
- B) To compare the writing from the manuscript to the painting.
- C) To investigate other Mount Athos monuments.
- D) To seek approval from Constantinos Vafiadis.